

Why Mulayam Lost?

- Despite three terms in the Lok Sabha, Akhilesh Yadav is still seen as a greenhorn lacking his father's famed political acumen.
- Mulayam already has his son, brothers and nephew in the Parliament and Assembly. His decision to field his daughter-in-law Dimple Yadav was seen by voters as the leader who began his political career opposing Congress's dynastic politics resorting to the same.
- Akhilesh, though popular among youth and students, did not grow on his own. Instead, he was always under the shadow of his father. He also has enemies within.
- Mulayam's continued friendship with Kalyan Singh angered many Muslim leaders who shifted to either the BSP or the Congress. The friendship also caused revulsion among his socialist and secular supporters.
- The way he defended the Ambanis in the Lok Sabha and spoke for hours in favour of capitalism alarmed his socialist comrades. He failed to take any lessons from the SP's 2007 and May 2009 defeats and continued to lose bypolls. By then, people had rejected his attempts to be seen with film stars and czars of industry.
- His claim that if voted back to power his Government would bulldoze all Mayawati statues also did not go well with the Dalit and backward caste voters.



(L-R) RAJ BABBAR, RAHUL GANDHI AND RITA BAHUGUNA-JOSHI

Though the results may warm the Congress cockles, the SP and the BSP will continue to be the two major contenders.

Lodh-Rajput combine. His hopes have been belied.

Interestingly, in the Etawah-Firozabad region, Mayawati had planted Ganga Charan Rajput, three-time Lok Sabha member and now a Rajya Sabha member, as the Lodh-Rajput leader. The move worked. One major factor contributing to Dimple's defeat was Charan Rajput's campaign against Kalyan's brand of politics; the Lodh-Rajputs did not vote for the SP despite Kalyan's firman. A smug Charan Rajput told INDIA TODAY that the time has come for Kalyan to retire and spend the rest of his life in Ayodhya.

But according to social anthropologist Badri Narayan, bypoll results don't set any trends. He says, "Mulayam's attempt to copy the Congress's dynastic politics, Rahul's campaign to raise accountability issue in public life and Mayawati's attempt to reconsolidate her Dalit votes and combine it with a section of backwards like Kurmis have

changed the contours of politics." Analysts say that the political scenario in Uttar Pradesh will remain tripolar with the Congress slowly re-emerging as a force. But in the coming days the contest might be confined to Mayawati and Mulayam.

BSP leaders claim that the SP's loss stemmed from Mayawati changing her Dalit strategy after the Lok Sabha elections by reserving seats for them in private institutes and providing them with government contracts. While Mulayam and SP General Secretary Amar Singh are busy devising a strategy to step up efforts to "expose" the misdeeds of the Mayawati regime, the BSP is expanding its base by making inroads into the powerful Kurmi caste. Encouraged by the stunning victory in Firozabad and Lucknow (West), the Congress and Rahul are also going the whole hog to turn Uttar Pradesh into a multipolar battlefield. But that is still a while away. ■